It Really Happened

A Thought on Parashat Lech Lecha

Dvar Torah - a printable page



In Parashat Lech Lecha we meet two people who each have to make an important decision: Avraham Avinu and Lot. Avraham and Lot had so much livestock and so many possessions that it became hard for them to stay together in one place. After a quarrel broke out between their shepherds, they decided to part ways. Lot looked around and saw the plain of the Jordan, a beautiful place full of life, and he chose to settle there, right next to Sodom. But there was a problem: the people of Sodom were very wicked. Even so, Lot was drawn to the beautiful place and chose to live right there.

Later in the parasha we see a completely different decision, made by Avraham Avinu. Avraham fought the four mighty kings, defeated them, and rescued Lot and the rest of the captives. After the victory, the king of Sodom wanted to give Avraham riches in return for what he had done, but Avraham refused to take even one small thing for himself. Why? Avraham didn't want the king of Sodom to be able to say that he was the one who made Avraham rich. He wanted it to be perfectly clear that his blessing and his success came only from Hashem, and not from the king of Sodom.

Notice the difference between the two choices. Lot looked at what seemed beautiful and attractive on the outside, and chose the place that suited what he wanted at that moment, without giving enough thought to the kind of people who lived there. Avraham, on the other hand, was ready to give up riches he could have had, because doing the right thing mattered more to him.

What can we learn from this? We also make many decisions every day, some small and some more important. A child can choose to do what all his friends are doing, even when he knows it isn't right. He can choose whatever is comfortable for him right now, even when he knows there's a better option. And sometimes he can choose to give up something he really wants, because he understands that it's the right thing to do.

Avraham Avinu teaches us that we can choose differently: to act out of faith, out of a wish to do what Hashem wants, and out of loyalty to our values. Sometimes the right choice means giving up something we want, but it's exactly those choices that help us grow. Every time we choose truth over illusion, and the right path over a passing desire, we take one more step toward becoming better and holier people. And that's a choice each of us can make, every single day.

Shabbat Shalom, and a blessed one!